

Occasionally, the idea of the state as a replacement for the family was taken to extremes. Soviet-era work farms took charge of children at a very early age and raised them to be good communists. At least, that was the idea. Free from the biases, privileges, and residual bourgeois sentiments of family life, a collectively raised child was supposed to be the “new man” the Soviets thought they needed. What they got was a failed experiment and a nation of alcoholics.

Still, in modern developed countries, people are meant to owe greater allegiance to the government than to their own kin. They pledge allegiance to the flag. They register for the draft. They pay taxes. When they are in need, they visit a government assistance center. When they have a health problem, they expect a government-funded health system to take care of them. When they are unemployed, they look to the government to pay them—and to tide them over until they find another job.

If unemployment is statistically high, they expect the government to take action to fix the problem. And if there is a natural disaster, such as the flooding of New Orleans, they look to the government to look out for them.

Yet government’s performance has been spotty. In fact, every study ever done concludes that the family can be far more helpful to an individual than the state. Schools with more parental involvement—in areas with “good” families—produce higher test results. People from successful families earn more money. People whose parents were happily married are more likely to be happily married themselves. Neighborhoods with stable, decent families have lower crime rates. People from good families even live longer.

People with some family money behind them are more likely to start successful businesses. Successful families help their members overcome problems. Help them get back on their feet when they fall. They help them in countless ways, most of them immeasurable.

Governments spend enormous amounts of money. Presumably, this money is intended to help people lead better lives. But there is no evidence that people are any better off. And there is strong reason to suspect that they would be better off if the money spent by the government had been left in the hands of the families it came from.

The growth in government, as a substitute for or competitor to families, coincided with a huge growth in wealth. Arguably, people accepted larger